

May 6. 2021 7 - 9 PM
Budget Hearing
Special Education
Notes

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn, Melanie McLaughlin 7 present 0 absent

Dave Murphy: School committee received documentation ahead of time; presenting slides on Pupil Services, available on MPS website

Three buckets

- Personnel
- Materials and infrastructure
- Professional development

Taking into account the disruption to education caused by COVID 19
\$2.1 M increase in fixed costs (includes \$1m in contractual increases)
FY22 Esser (covid related)funding from federal government
2 large buckets estimated ESSER II and ESSER III
MPS receives many grants to support Special Education (slide listing grant sources)

Joan Bowen: thanks to all the Special Education staff that have worked so hard this year.

Key Priorities:

- Additional staffing capacity to meet needs and compliance
- ETL at AMS
Additional Connections Classroom at Roberts (k-5)
- Contracted services
- Shifting in responsibilities to better support students
- Additional nursing support
- Increased training for Paras (registered behavioral therapists)
- Increase in Behavioral Specialists Position
- K-1 teacher training in Orton-Gillingham
- COVID testing coordinator
- Medicaid billing team
- Building Based PD at Curtis Tufts
- Recovery HS enrollment support (Boston or Beverly sites - tuition)
- .6 full time school counselor for English Learners.

Stacey Schulman - we will need more BCBA support on the elementary level

- Increase to 4 Behavioral Specialists positions at the para level
- Line item for recovery high school tuition
- .6 time school counselor for ELs

School Nurses: Toni Wray:

Ask: testing manager and COVID support

Currently using Northeastern Nursing students

Need: team of 4 people who could rotate schools for testing

Drauschke: Curtis Tufts Budget Priorities

Expansion of Special/Electives teacher to half time position to facilitate learning opportunities that could be most valuable to students: flexibility of scheduling in elective offerings, current schedule focuses on academic opportunities with art offered one time a day.

Paul Ruseau: Do we advertise for a .6 FTE? Are we able to find people at this level?

Dave Murphy: It well might be the case that we will need to hire a 1.0. The other factor is it may be the case of applicant pool desiring a 1.0 position. We could split the cost between Esser funding and our budget.

Paul Ruseau: I want to avoid the case that turns out to be like when we didn't have full time nurses in the past. Similarly, we didn't have enough adjustment counselors all the time. I want to hear you say that for our EL population, that there will be someone in this role 5 days a week.

Dave Murphy: When we talk about a .6 position, that is not to say that the services are not there for the students 3 days a week. Ms. Schulman's department is responsible for all students. We are all responsible for all students. We talked about the departmentalization of this budget. It is unacceptable for any person to think they are only responsible for a particular segment of students. We need to break down the silos.

7:54: Melanie McLaughlin : I have a lot of questions. This is a complex aspect of the budget. Pupil services covers a lot of areas. Important for people to see the listing of the programs at each school. I will ask programmatic elements as they relate to budget as well

Language Based: Mentioned that there is grade level access for the program. I would like to clarify: the Access program says they use MA curriculum frameworks. Aren't all of these sub separate classrooms and segregated programs grade level?

Joan: They follow frameworks but may be significantly modified for access as opposed for our language based programs..

Melanie: Access students will still get grade level content?

Joan: Yes

Melanie: Resource room opportunities at all schools and all programming levels? For the special education sheet, it says MHS and voc tech but you go back to the presentation, it says resource rooms at each school. What does that look like?

Joan: Resource rooms are across the district. It is for a specific area such as math for students who do not need a sub-separate setting all day long. Resource rooms provide scaffolding for reading, writing, project help, test taking skills, organizational skills: Special education meets the needs for the subject they are working on.

Melanie: Across all levels of disability?

Joan Bowen : Yes

Melanie: When I was doing the math on this document, Spec. Ed. by schools, program; when I was adding it up it got to 80 paras?

Dave Murphy: There are vacancies but that is the ballpark. (76 is what I had.)

Jenny Graham: I have a health services question. Medicaid billing team: what revenue gets generated from medicaid billing?

Toni Wray: I don't have the exact amount. The revenues go to the city. I did a pilot program for a student last year. We were able to recoup 12 to 15k over five months. Last year they expanded the medicaid coverage to all students who have mass health coverage. There is also an expansion with speech, language and OT. There is potential to recover some money. It is heavily regulated and requires someone who is trained in that billing process.

Jenny Graham: I am only in favor if it comes to MPS. We can't spend money to generate money that doesn't come back to the district. It is an investment worth making as long as the return is there to offset the cost.

Toni Wray: There is a lot of lobbying towards that. It requires a lot of monitoring. It would take a full time role to do this process for all students.

Jenny Graham: I can't correlate how staff is spread out among buildings. Can you describe where we are headed in that regard.

Stacey Schulman; Many roles have overlapping responsibilities. Some schools have .5; some schools have a full time school psychologist. Full time psychologists provide counseling services so there will be fewer adjustment counselors in the building. There is also additional staff in buildings with specialized programs. We are looking to streamline services for next year. In my more detailed budget, you will see more detail about the placement.

Jenny Graham: There is a method to the madness?

Stacey Schulman: Yes.

Jenny Graham: It doesn't look super rational. There is widespread acknowledgement that we need additional support at the elementary level. I don't know how to evaluate it at the moment because the numbers don't seem to make sense. Are we incrementally adding to everyone? What is the goal? Is it enough?

Dave Murphy: It is important to spell it out. Especially with the ESSER funding coming in. There is a rationale now as to how the employees are being deployed. What is the best plan forward when it comes to this funding? We need to identify the best practices

Kathy Kreatz: Boiler repair at the Curtis Tufts? I am curious if there is any information about this?

Dave Murphy: This has to take place in the next 6 months. We created a bridge solution but it needs to be fixed to keep the building open. The capital repairs necessary at the CT are comprehensive. I give credit to Mr. Drauschke for making it work in such an old building with significant challenges.

Kathy Kreatz: Refillable water stations with the Esser funds?

Dave Murphy: Between grant funding and Esser funding, we need to address these needs.

Paulette Van der Kloot: National Nurses Day today. Happy Nurses Day to our nursing staff this year.

Toni Wray: would not necessarily require nurses, graduates of public health. Team of four could travel among schools. Would be dependent on public health need. Similar to the contact tracing staff.

Dave Murphy: That is a microcosm of what we are talking about. Many positions are short term due to need. There are positions that we can try to make sustainable going forward.

Mea Mustone: Can you screen share page 7; supt. Draft recommendations: page 7 and 8: Whole department. Under the director's personnel priorities, it lists 13 bullets - all of the priorities are in superintendent except for behavioral specialist, meep asst and admin for curtis tufts high school. They all seem worthy of being on the supt. Recommendations.

Dave Murphy: As a point of process, the first table lists staff, the second is the superintendent's draft recommendations, the third is from the dept. Heads themselves as a response to the SC wanting to see the budget process. Sometimes a director advocates for something but we know

it might be covered elsewhere in the budget. I am pretty confident that these roles live elsewhere in the budget. There are other instances where the directors advocate for something but it is not a priority. The two tracks: we are giving authentic representation as we can but we need to operate the district regardless of what funding is delivered. At a minimum the administrative assistant at the Curtis Tufts might not make the cut. We have to make a choice about adding staff in other areas in that building that better serve the needs of students. Focused on direct support. We might be asking you for that decision later in the process.

Mea Mustone; I would like to make a recommendation to include the Superintendent's list in the budget.

Kathy Kreatz: I second that.

Jenny Graham: can I ask a clarifying question: are you including the covid priorities in the motion?

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Can we pull up the supt recommendations?

Mea Mustone: Yes I am comfortable including all four categories in the motion.

Melanie McLaughlin: I have questions on behavioral specialist, additional spec. Ed teacher for the Brooks and paraprofessional training.

What classroom at Brooks?

Joan Bowen: Resource room

Melanie McLaughlin: Are they full time to the Resource room? Just resource room?

Joan Bowen: Less than eight we don't require a para. They are identified as Special ed. Resource room teachers.

Melanie McLaughlin: Developmental classroom?

Joan Bowen: Katie Capuccio's class: students with significant disabilities: modified curriculum.

Melanie McLaughlin: for the training for the Paras:

Joan Bowen: To become registered behavioral specialists. Using ABA.

Melanie McLaughlin: Is that going to be offered to all paras?

Joan Bowen: Yes. Contracted service. All online. Get certification at the end of the course.

Melanie McLaughlin: Adjustment counselor vs. behavioral specialist.

Stacey Schulman: Behavioral specialist ABA
Adjustment counselor mental health counselor. Masters level.
4 BCBA's in the district.

Dave Murphy: The green check marks in the critical budget. Priorities are reflective of our conversation at the Monday meeting. There are some pieces that we will ask you not to include to take into account the fact that we continue to strategize the use of resources. Long term budget. Priorities: middle ground between proposals that didn't make it to supt. Recommendations. As time goes on, if we have the budget, we recognize the importance of these items. There are also instances like the CT admin asst. We have devised other strategies that might address those needs. I anticipate we will fund a floating administrative asst. Position to CT and other offices. When we get to May 19, we will take the endorsements you have offered and present to you those items that are "either or". There is a range between 3.4 and 5.8 million. Lot of movement. We appreciate the support that is represented by the motion.

Melanie McLaughlin: If I understand the motion, it is to accept the Supt's recommendations with the understanding that we are continuing to make other considerations.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: On Monday we made a motion to include items in the final budget for May 19.

How many positions will be added and how can we maintain those after COVID? Want to avoid structural deficits and layoffs in 2025.

Dave Murphy: Votes we are taking now inform what we bring to you on May 19. If you have a philosophical objection, now is the time to tell us. We want to make sure we make the budget in line with the SC's priorities. It would be imprudent if we fund a slew of teaching positions with ESSER funds - it would be unsustainable. There are urgent needs attached to the pandemic that we will suggest to address the gaps we are facing.

Melanie McLaughlin: I do have concerns that I need to bring up. Contracted services for helping support less out of district placement?

Joan Bowen: Speech and language and OT services. We would like to increase their hours.

Melanie McLaughlin: Regarding JG's question around the narrative and how staff are distributed around buildings? Specifically we are looking at student supports and equity. Are we providing salary increases for paras with the extra BA training? How do we address high turnover rates in the para staff? How many are one to one? How many are in the classrooms? How many are substitutes? Absenteeism of paras? If we are not looking at how we are allocating these paras to the classroom, then we are looking at equity. No co-teaching at the elementary level. Very complex department. I would be asking for these big picture items.

Para allocation in the McGlynn is a problem. No unified art or PE - no adaptive instruction: how are we differentiating curriculum. There are bigger pieces we are not talking about right now.

Dave Murphy: We are talking about these things in a very extensive way. We have the goal of having more students in inclusive environments. Special education has to be a fully integrated part of our program. We need to find the most effective strategies to achieve that environment. Whether it is hiring more personnel or training existing personnel. This budget and the proposals coming before you are an attempt to build more inclusive environments.

Paul Ruseau : Being fiscally conservative because we are afraid of the budget in three years would be irresponsible. The kids are struggling now. We should be wildly aggressive in meeting those needs. It has been uncomfortable for 39 years since prop 2.5 was passed. If in three years, we have to lay people off but we keep kids from going

8:50 break - 9:00

Jenny Graham: In the balance it will settle out what will happen in three years. If we had a strategic plan in place, this would be so much easier. Before we don't have the plan well in place, we are needing to rationalize spending money that the federal government has bestowed on us. We were not where we wanted to be before the pandemic hit. I am not afraid to spend money right now so we can have discussions about what has to happen.

I would like to move Mea Mustone's motion.

Mea Mustone: The superintendents recommendations (all four levels) will be included in the budget.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: For us to review for final discussion at the end of the month.

Kathy Kreatz: Seconded

Paul Ruseau : Ms. Bowen when students enter the district with mental health needs, will they be placed on IEP's?

Joan Bowen: Yes

Paul Ruseau: The only option for mental health might be in the school system. So hard to get an appointment.

Joan Bowen: We are looking to get a counselor just for the EL. I anticipate a large number of referrals in the fall for social emotional and learning disabilities.

Paul Ruseau: I am concerned that kids' needs will escalate and create a bigger demand on your services and on Ms. Schulman's services. I am worried as to how quickly we can respond

to these needs. ESSER would clearly qualify for covering these positions. Perhaps more training for people currently in the district.

Dave Murphy: That is why we are including the fourth row. There is an overlap and the interests collide. We are building the budgets concurrently. I am more concerned with finding personnel than having the funding. Every district is talking about this right now and will be in hiring mode and we have to be competitive to bring the talent in asap.

Roll call: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn, Melanie McLaughlin 7 yay 0 nay: motion passes

Motion to adjourn: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn, Melanie McLaughlin 7 yay, - nay: meeting adjourned at 9:08